

Web Alert - 5 Great Web Sites



www.parnasse.com/vrml.shtml

VRML (Virtual Reality Markup Language) enthusiasts have created lots of VRML worlds for you—worlds that you can navigate in, in 3D. This site is a collection of such worlds. Just google on “VRML worlds” for more such. For a VRML plugin, which you’ll need, head to www.parallelgraphics.com/products/cortona/



www.airbagindustries.com/introvertster/index.php

Introvertster “is an online community that prevents stupid people and friends from harassing you online.” Sign up here so you can “avoid invites to chat, make it impossible for a friend to send you an IM,” and generally, spread the idea that you don’t care too much for personal communication.



www.straightdope.com

This is a fun site packed with information about fun everyday things. These things include articles, FAQs, and answers on stuff such as whether Vikings really wore helmets, whether there ever was a female Pope, and so on. There are cartoons, there’s a message board, and you can sign up for the mailing list.



www.kuroshin.org

“Technology and culture, from the trenches”—you’ve got to take a look at the site to believe the sheer range of content: there’s something for everyone. Sections range from science and technology to politics and media. You can write articles too, besides commenting on and discussing existing ones. The site is copiously hyperlinked, which is fun.



www.infoanarchy.org/

This is an eminently accessible news and discussion place for the more technologically and Internet-oriented amongst us—for example, there’s lots of the latest P2P news. There’s a Wiki, there are diaries by members, there are news stories, and so on. As in Kuroshin, you can put up your content on the site. Very informative, very “with it”.

ries no royalty fees and can run on just about everything. “We can be ported to many platforms that Opera can’t... Mozilla has been developed to work on every flavour of UNIX and every type of processor, chip or widget set.”

Opera is the Microsoft of the mobile browsing market and is unlikely to take Minimo lightly after what Firefox did to Internet Explorer’s market share. A spokeswoman with Opera questioned the Foundation’s experience in the mobile market saying, “We have been working on mobile browsers for six years... These are interest-

ing comments, although I am not sure that delivering on many flavours of UNIX is going to get you onto very many mobile phones.”

For the moment, though, it appears that the Minimo team has a fair bit of work to do before really taking on the might of Opera. Their application is targeted at portable platforms with 32 to 64 MB of RAM and Linux, which seriously limits the appeal of the browser. Opera’s browser runs great series 60 phones without a hitch, and can be installed on just about any other next generation mobile device.

Minimo may have more

to contribute than a simple HTML browser. Developers have been churning out new ideas for improving the usability of Web sites on small-screen devices, such as re-flowing content to eliminate horizontal scrolling without discarding page elements, page zooming, and non-linear navigation of hyperlinks. If this team can find a way to shrink the mammoth Mozilla code-base into something that will run well on a cell phone as well as continue to innovate, Opera may very well find themselves in the midst of their own browser war.

COMPUTER LITERACY

And This Is How You Open A Document Ma’am

In an attempt to increase computer literacy in Indian schools,” Microsoft launched the “Connected Learning Program” in about 150 top schools in India. To



facilitate this, they launched a low-cost version of MS Office; “Office Student and Teacher Edition 2003” (Rs 6,950).

The product aims to

leverage technology to make the learning process more effective and fun for both student and teacher. Student-Teacher Office enables students to work on school-related projects from home. Special features include a research task pane, integrated help, interactive online training, templates for educational and home tasks, and an improved Reading Pane in MS Office Outlook 2003.

TERRORISTS OR GAMERS?

CIA to spy on IRC

It has recently become known that the Central Intelligence Agency (CIA) has been funding research into IRC monitoring.

According to a report on ZDNet UK, money has been received by the Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute in New York. One of its proposals received almost \$158,000 in grants, which will enable it to build a program for “silently listening” to IRC channels and logging messages. The two men behind the proposal, Bulent Yener and M Krishnamoorthy, state in a paper released in June that their work “could aid [the] intelligence community to eavesdrop in chat-rooms, profile chatters and identify hidden groups of chatters cost effectively.”

One can’t help but worry that this is, in fact, legit. The proposal mentions monitoring the under-net network: far from being the hive of terrorists that the CIA might think, all they’re likely to catch are song and movie swappers.

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Buzzword of the MONTH

Indexing

With so many desktop search tools to choose from now—whereas there were none just a couple of months ago—indexing has become a buzzword. Complaints abound about what Google

Desktop Search does not index. MSN Desktop Search Beta is actually just an extension of the indexing service built into Windows 2000 and XP. Copernic’s offering boasts of “up to 200 per cent faster indexing”. And in HotBot’s tool, you have more control over the indexing process.